



Global Returnship Policy

Scope

This policy applies to all applicants for the Returnship program (collectively “Applicants”), and Returnship Program participants (collectively “Returners”).

Guiding Principles

Cognizant supports an inclusive environment and believes that this is a key for success in the digital world. Aligned with this commitment the Cognizant® Returnship Program helps technology professionals return to the corporate world after a career break.

The Cognizant Returnship Program is a three (3) month paid program for professionals who have taken an extended career break and want to re-enter the workforce. The program runs periodically across different Cognizant global locations and businesses, based on need and at the company’s discretion, following local laws. Through the program, Returners build on their past work experience while gaining new skills through training, mentoring, networking, hands-on projects, and visibility to senior management teams.

To join the program, experienced professionals must have at least five (5) years of experience and a career break of at least 18 months. Returners are hired at the Senior Associate to Associate Director level. Any deviations from these criteria will be specified in country addendums.

In addition to these joining requirements, the application process needs applicants to follow Cognizant’s regional hiring policies. Assessments may be done to check skills, experience, and the ability to learn new skills. Background checks are done according to the [Global Background Verification Policy](#).

Upon selection into the Returnship Program, Returners are employed on a Fixed Term Contract (FTC) or as a Full Time Employee (FTE). Returners on an FTC are on probation for three (3) months of the Program duration, as mentioned in their contract. Returners hired as FTEs will start the Program under a probation period of three (3) months, as mentioned in their offer and in accordance with local laws. All employment is subject to having the required work authorization in the country of application. The [Returnship Program management team](#) will make final decisions on applicant eligibility.

Key definitions

Cognizant Returnship Program: a paid professional program for Returners who have taken an extended career break and are looking to re-enter the workforce. The program draws on the past experience of individuals and is augmented with upskilling and live projects.

Returners: Individuals who have taken a career break and are re-entering the workforce through the Cognizant® Returnship program.

Related policies & Processes

- [Diversity and Inclusion Policy - LATAM](#)
- [Diversity and Inclusion Policy - Canada](#)
- [Diversity and Inclusion Policy - USA](#)
- [Diversity and Inclusion Policy - EMEA](#)
- [Diversity and Inclusion Policy - APJ](#)
- [Code of Ethics](#)
- [Regional hiring policies](#)
- [Global Background Verification Policy](#)
- [Global Referral Policy](#)
- [Appendix](#)

During the Program, Returners receive a mid-term evaluation at about six (6) weeks into the program. At the end of the three (3)-month program, Returners are provided final evaluations.

Upon Program completion, both FTC and FTE Returners may be offered continued work with Cognizant based on business needs and performance.

For FTC Returners specifically, the contract will end after three months. If Cognizant offers continued work, FTC Returners will get new contracts with level fitment and pay based on experience and job grade. However, if Cognizant does not offer continued work, they may apply to open jobs via the Cognizant career website.

Meanwhile, FTE Returners will have different outcomes based on their evaluations and feedback. Therefore, FTE Returners will either continue their work, extend their probation period, or end their work based on evaluations and business unit feedback, in compliance with local laws.

Whether FTC Returners start a new contract or FTE Returners continue work, both will follow Cognizant's standard policies and procedures, including the performance management process. Please refer to the [Global Performance Management Policy](#) for more details.

Associates that refer candidates for the Returnship Program can be recognized and rewarded in accordance with the [Global Referral Policy](#) in cases where employment is continued at the end of the Returnship program.

Exception Handling

Any exception to this policy needs explicit approval from the Global Returnship Program Leader and Regional HR Lead and/or Regional Talent Acquisition Lead, or their designee.

Policy Modifications

Cognizant reserves the right to amend its policies as necessary. Any changes to this policy will be approved by the Head of Diversity & Inclusion.

Version History

Revision Date	Description of Change
JUN-07-2021	Initial release
SEP-20-2023	General refresh with additions to include requirements for continued employment in India, high level details about probationary periods, Returnship candidate referrals, Global Returnship Program Leader added to exception process, policy owner and modification approver updated from Head of HR Ops to Head of D&I.
APR-11-2025	Specific criteria for applicant eligibility, role placement and India specific probationary period have been added to the India Addendum. Probationary period modified to include all regions. The cooling off period under the conclusion section, moved from main policy to India Addendum.
JAN-21-2026	Specific criteria for applicant eligibility, role placement and program conclusion & future opportunities have been updated in the India addendum.

Policy Control Information

Policy Name: Global Returnship Policy

Revision Date: JAN-21-2026

Policy Owner: Global Head, Diversity & Inclusion

Department: Human Resources

Effective Date: JUN-07-2021

Appendix

India addendum

The India addendum to the Global Returnship Policy will align with the main policy, with certain sections tailored specifically for India, including:

Applicant eligibility

The program is intended for professionals who have a minimum of two (2) years of experience and have taken at least a 12-month break from their professional career.

Role placement

Returners are hired into the Cognizant Returnship Program and placed at Programmer Analyst (PA) to Associate Director levels.

Probation period

Cognizant may decide to extend an employee's probation period by an additional three months on an individual basis. If this happens, the employee will be informed and given constructive feedback on areas to focus on. At the end of the extended probation period, based on the evaluation, they will either be confirmed in their position or their offer will conclude, initiating a separation process.

Program Conclusion & Future Opportunities

Upon successful completion of the probation period, FTE's will maintain their existing compensation and job level.